making me want you

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Teen And Up Audiences

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Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Trans Adora (She-Ra), Nonbinary Adora (She-Ra), 18th Century, Alternate Universe - Arranged Marriage, if it was mixed with, a Cinderella au, Era aesthetic, Y'all want some... historical innacuracy?, its fine, its fantasy, I claim it as worldbuilding, You've heard of horse girl Adora, Now get ready for horse girl Catra, Alternate Universe - Medieval, Prince Adora, Lady Catra, Alternate Universe - Historical

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by Adertily

Summary

The first time Catra sees Adora, it's a glance of gold in the corner of her eye that brings her mind to the middle of summer and the fields of barley a few miles out the backdoor of her family's estate. It's the scent of lilacs that follows their skin like ribbons of silk; Catra feels her own heart thump within her ribcage at the memories of the bunches that hang from the kitchen's window cill. It's every way their voice is soft as they take a little breath, as though they're stunned. Perhaps understandably. Before Adora offers a bemused, "Hi."

Catra was certain that whatever tapestries they made of this moment in generations to come, it's the way her eyes drifted to meet Adora's that would be the very first touch of thread onto that blank canvas.

And it's tragic. Because, looking as handsome as sin in their white and gold naval accoutre, Adora's standing before her, and Catra doesn't even know.

Notes

A note on Adora's pronouns, the use of both 'they' and 'she' was used intentionally and will be explained by Adora later on. She goes by both, but prefers people to use they/them in formal settings, which is why everyone bar herself and Glimmer address her as such. Prince is also a title within this verse, which they are comfortable with and do not feel the need to change. I'm nb myself so please put your weapons away.

Another thing, this fic will have about 4 chapters if I can finish it, but I'm making no promises, so it will be marked as completed for now and updated as things progress.

And thank you Sydney for helping!

Adora paces the tiled path in the orchard gardens like some trapped creature, her hands clammy and her face still flushed from the court meeting they've just stepped out of. Glimmer watches her from a bench under the shade of the branches of a cherry tree. Amused, evidently.

"I just don't see why it's *necessary*." Adora pouts, yanking out her tunic from where it's tucked into the belt of her breeches, needing the little bit of freedom it gains to help cool her down. The only reply from her cousin is a hike in one eyebrow. "Like, I'm fine!" Adora continues. "I don't see why this has to happen *now,* isn't the coronation enough of a monumental life shift that we can leave the other stuff—" she gestures a hand through the air as though she's trying to shoo it away. "—a little while longer?"

"The *other stuff*?" Glimmer rebukes, crossing one leg over the other. The folds of her skirt shift, a material that makes Adora wince every time the other girl dares to wear it *outdoors.* "Getting married, you mean?"

Adora stops her pacing, she only realises she's started biting at her nails because Glimmer's suddenly standing, moving toward her, and pulling her hands away from her teeth.

"Look," Glimmer begins, soft. "None of us expect you to rush into this. The ball's just a start. A way of putting things in motion so you actually have a chance to meet people."

"But I *have* people, I have you, and Bow—"

"Yes. But when you take the crown the nobles will expect you to rule from the *Capital*, not from Brightmoon." Glimmer reminds her, squeezing Adora's hands within her own. "And we'll visit as much as we can but you can't be in that castle all alone, you know that."

Adora starts to speak, flounders, and then her shoulders sag. Finally, she says, quiet. "But what if nobody likes me?"

Glimmer scoffs, Adora assumes it's intended to be bolstering. "I think you'd be hard-pressed to find someone attending that ball that wouldn't immediately throw themselves at your feet." Glimmer rolls her eyes, letting go of Adora's hands before returning to the bench. "You'll be swarmed all evening."

Yes, but that's the problem.

Everyone will smile as sweet as honey and greet her as the *heir to the throne* - and not as Adora. She lets out a cornered sound then, and it has Glimmer's expression softening.

"You know this isn't a punishment right? That we all just want you to be happy, to find someone who can be that for you."

Like Bow is for Glimmer, like Angella is for Micah. But that's different because they're all actually *in love.* Given her circumstances, given most human *motives*, that's not feasibly in the cards for Adora.

She starts pacing again.

"Look," Glimmer sighs. "Stop thinking about this as some intimidating theoretical, alright, either you meet someone you like, in which case, yay, you get to spend more time with them. Or you *don't.* And we have Swift Wind moved into one of the spare wings of the castle so you at least have some sort of company to keep you sain," Her shoulders rise and fall in a shrug. "Simple."

Adora thinks the noise she is making now is closer to that of a kicked puppy.

"Okay," Glimmer rolls her eyes. "One ball. Just one, and if we get nowhere we'll all drop the subject until you want to bring it up again yourself. Deal?"

Adora considers, and then nods emphatically.

Fireflies dance above the canopy of trees over Catra's head like stars at twilight as she leads Melog down the cobbled track and through the wooden gates of the paddock.

The scent of lavender carries in the air from where they've spent the day harvesting the north field, and it clings to Melog's coat still, despite the buckets of water she'd thrown over his back to cool him after riding — steam rising from his dappled fur like mist.

Kyle, their stablehand, hadn't even argued this time. Aware that every attempt at, "My lady, I should be doing that for you," had earned him nothing but heatless growls. Besides, Catra'd always take the excuse to delay her return to the house a little while longer, and Melog had *worked* for her. He deserved a little pampering.

She wonders then, idly as she walks, if she might get away with stealing another pair of the stable boy's breeches. He's far scrawnier than she is, she swears it, but his clothes just seem to *fit* in a way her gowns never do. She won't ask of course. But if a set were to go missing while out under the sun on the drying line, who's to know? It's not like she's currently strutting around adorned in her previous attempt at thievery. (The trousers are just comfortable, okay?)

Her hands move to work the metal buckles of Melog's halter to slip him loose once they're in the pasture, though even when he is free, the dark-grey gelding still walks in step beside her like he intends to follow her right back to the house.

"I swear you were somebody's lapdog in a previous life," she jests, only opening the gate back up the pinch she needs to squeeze *herself* through, and not the eight-hundred-pound creature that wants to follow. "Go," she jingles the headcollar and lead rope toward him, a signal of dismissal she knows well won't be enough to startle him. "Be free."

Melog snorts out a puff of warm air before he reluctantly turns to leave, and Catra begins strolling back toward the house disappointed that the sunlight hadn't given her a few minutes more of the evening.

Catra sneaks in through the back door. She's always preferred being greeted by the rosy, smiling faces of the cooks and maids over the blank expression of the steward, who'd steadfastly *insist* on opening the front doors *for* her. She has arms, does she not?

She takes an apple as she passes a fruit bowl. No one protests, naturally. Her teeth pierce a bite from it as she weaves her way through old, dusty corridors and over floorboards that creak under her feet. She can't wait to kick her blessed riding boots off when she gets back to her room, they're one of the few things she tolerates for necessity, but they're still not pleasant when she'd rather feel the ground under her toes.

Her footfalls turn light and weightless as she passes an open doorway, her tail ready to balance, one ear swivels as it picks up on the presence of an inhabitant, but—

"Catra," A voice as cold and shrewd as always calls from the room. "Octavia tells me you did not attend your lessons this afternoon."

Caught, Catra enters, noting the way Weaver's eyes don't even rise from the parchment that's strewn across the desk she's sat at, a desk that had once belonged to Catra's father, she's told. But, thankfully, it also means her guardian doesn't witness the grudge-fueled twitch of the last few vertebrae in Catra's tail.

"It was sunny." She shrugs. "It hadn't been all week, I wanted to take advantage of it." She moves, perching on the edge of the desk only because she knows it will irritate its occupant.

“It would do you good to take advantage of your *tutor*,” Weaver says, completely sober.

Catra makes a clicking noise with the corner of her mouth, it’s the one thing that stops her from smirking. “Perhaps.” She agrees airily. “But I don’t believe she is that way inclined, actually.” Then, she takes an obnoxiously loud bite from the fruit still in her hand, revelling in the way Weaver’s eyes roll.

“We do have to *pay* her, you know.” Weaver’s notes, ignoring Catra’s previous remark, as though the loss of funds should sting Catra as much as it does her. “Even when you're off galavanting around the grounds with that *beast* of yours.”

“Melog is not a beast, he’s a beautiful, noble steed, who—”

“Catra, I have things to attend to,” She interrupts, a dismissal as clear and sharp as glass. “I will see you at dinner.”

Curt, as always.

Catra wonders if her guardian had even noticed the scuff marks on her chin and the bruising that is growing below the skin there. (Melog had startled at a hare, but what was new.)

The older woman’s quill raps a little too harshly against the side of the inkwell after she dips it, before her hand’s gliding over parchment, no doubt signing off on some business of the estate she considers Catra still too young to handle.

It’s not an injustice, not really, not if it means Catra’s free to, how had Weaver put it? Galavant?

Catra sighs before slipping off the desk.

Catra's halfway through eating a shank of lamb with her bare hands, letting the fragments of bone clatter onto the floral, ceramic plate in front of her when Weaver drops the news *oh so* casually.

It arrives in a letter. Rogelio delivers it on an ostentatious silver platter, bowing as he leaves.

She's got them all well trained, Catra thinks, not for the first time. It's a wonder that she herself could get away with sitting at the dining table barefoot, cross-legged, and still in her riding attire, when every other aspect of the house is *precise* and *proper* to an extent it makes Catra want to wretch. It's a small mercy that Weavers' lack of interest toward having Catra married off grants her these inelegancies.

It's no mystery as to her guardian's reasoning, if Catra were to gain a husband, (she cringes every time at the thought) then the estate would become *his.*

So, predictably, Weaver lets her remain feral so no one gets any ideas of courting the local heiress. The few *still* brave enough to try soon give up. Her practised glare, by now, is willing to *murder*, even if her claws, in good conscience, will not. They're all so *easy* to flash though.

Weaver's eyes scan the letter, and it's with a level of attention that has Catra listening for news with one ear at attention.

"I assume you have heard about the Brightmoon ball next month..." Delivery has always been Weaver's brand of dramatic, and her voice cutting through the silence that'd been in the dining room before makes Catra pause entirely, glance up.

She replies slowly. "I had." She's always *aware* of these things, but they're of little significance on her radar when she's rarely attended. Rarely been *made* to attend. But there's also the luminous fact that this ball is a *Brightmoon ball.* One of the first in years to be hosted by one of the wealthiest families in Etheria.

Catra's rib cage stills, hoping for the usual insouciance that Weaver often ends with regarding these matters.

Instead, she gets, "You will be attending."

Catra scowls, but she's not certain it will be the deterrent she's searching for. "Are you serious?"

"Very." Weaver nods once. "And I expect you to behave this time. It is important our house makes a good impression, after all—"

My house, Catra thinks, her forehead in a pinch as Weaver rambles on. She decides she's going to return to her dinner. She can complain to her pillow about the ridiculousness of balls, and dresses and other frivolities later, perhaps even scribble down an irate note to send to Scorpia in the morning about this most recent maltreatment.

She nearly chokes on her food when she catches the end of Weaver's speech. "—received news from a reliable source that Prince Adora, now that they are of age, will be using the event to search for a wife, so I hope you can appreciate the opportunity to __"

Catra's ears prick, though she's no longer listening.

Prince Adora, the current *heir to the throne*.

See, this is one sneaky loophole to the whole *having an heiress as a ward* problem. And actually, it's sorta genius on Weavers part, because so long as Catra's shipped off to live with a family that's wealth dwarfs her own, they'd have no need for the modest estate, and Weaver could keep running it, without even Catra as a threat (though quite a lethargic one), to her comfy position of authority.

It's a fat fucking chance though. Catra *knows* Weaver knows that too. She returns to her dinner, smirking. "So this whole event is some undisguised attempt to parade all the local lord's daughter's around like a herd of prized cows."

Weaver actually looks up at that. Blinks, then, "Young lady, what on Etheria have you done to your face?"

Oh yeah, the bruise. "Nothing." Catra shifts in her chair, hoping her hair will fall to hide it.

Weaver places the letter down on the table, leaning back in her seat. Voice *cold*. "If you can't get that animal under control—"

"I am *in* control." She returns, her jaw tense, her tail thudding against the leg of the chair. And it might be a white lie, but Melog is all she has. Control is for masochists anyway.

"Catra—"

"It's my own fault," She shrugs. "I sent him over a hedge, I misjudged the distance."

She doesn't know if Weaver can tell she's lying, but the fire is simmering down behind the older woman's eyes and it feels a little less like her horse is about to be threatened.

Weaver ends simply with, "That bruise better fade before the ball."

"It will." And Catra will just have to be careful not to get *more.*

Catra wakes to the melody of birdsong outside a crack in her window. She's already striding down the track to the paddock by the time she knows her tutor and guardian will be rousing. Melog greets her at the gate like he'd *known.* Complying to leave the company of the estate's working horses as she rushes him towards the stables and throws a saddle over his back, before sneaking out of the grounds. It seemed, Catra thought, that he

was even purposefully stepping over softer ground to dampen the echo of his feet as they went.

Regardless, they're gone before anyone knows.

Scorpia's house is only a few miles away, it's a pleasant morning and she's in no mood to rush. It would not be wise so soon after Melog's breakfast anyway, and the steady shift of his muscles under the saddle as he plods along has always been the best kind of meditation.

She nods warmly to the few commoners they pass — many have been working the land here since before she was born. Most had known her parents well, and it grants her genuine smiles in return. A lump forms in her throat every time. To know that they were so *loved* — and that she'd never gotten to learn the gentleness that would have earned them such a reputation that the warmness of their tenants now extended to her too. She doesn't deserve it. She'd fight against every one of Weavers austerity measures if she did.

Catra pushes Melog to walk just that little bit faster.

Her friend's cottage is small on the horizon, hollyhocks grow along the front wall like a brigade at attention, and ivy climbs up towards the thatched roof as though it's trying to reach the clouds. Catra beams to herself as they approach.

She tucks Melog's saddle and bridle under the shelter of a log shed after releasing him into the small, enclosed field that borders the house, it's mostly filled with chickens, but they're familiar enough with the gelding not to raise a raucous alarm as he starts to graze. Catra lets herself inside.

Her friend's making a flower arrangement in a vase atop the kitchen table when Catra finds her, sunlight falling onto the petals through the window behind.

"Oh, hey, Wildcat!" Scorpia, suspiciously, looks *sheepish* when she glances over. Her arm twitches like she's intending to *hide* her work, perhaps shove it behind a cupboard door, before she thinks better of it.

"God, I hope they're not for me Scorp, you know they make me sneeze." It's a jest, because she knows Scorpia had gotten over that crush *years* ago.

"Huh? Oh! The flowers!" Scorpia stammers, the palms of her hands run nervously down the front of her dress skirt. "No. No, they're not for you." She lets out an awkward laugh.

Catra raises an eyebrow.

"They're… for my mom! Yeah. They're for my mom." Scorpia starts nodding like she's proud of herself, and Catra's not going to point out that there was nothing subtle about that at all. "Anyway, what can I do for you, Cat— uh, my lady?"

"Jeez Scorp, drop the formalities, you know they make me want to hurl." She picks up one of the flower stems from the table, twirling it in her fingers. The D'Ream's have been in retainer to her family for generations, she'd been told they'd even followed their emigration from Purrsia back when Catra's own grandmother was just a kit. Knights for the most part, chicken keepers (and hobbyist florists, it would seem) on the side. The whole 'my lady' thing, Catra knows, is because Weaver thinks they're far too informal with each other. Catra continues, "But I actually could use your help. You don't happen to still have that nightshade bush around back do you?"

"Catra." Scorpia's voice is all fond disapproval.

Catra's is all faux innocence. "What?"

“You are not poisoning yourself to get out of a social event again, you *know* what happened last time.”

“It *worked*, is what happened.”

“You were sick for three days!” Scorpia protests. “You hallucinated that Melog was a giant, purple cat creature! I was worried you were going to *die*, Catra, and I couldn’t even inform the physician what you’d taken because it would have been really god-damn suspicious that I was so certain, and then *I* would have gotten in trouble. But you know what? I would have thrown that all away if it meant keeping you *alive*.”

Catra winces. “Alright, so I got the dose a *little* wrong.”

“A little?” Scorpia folds her arms. “I can’t honestly believe that whatever it is you’re desperate to get out of could be worse than three days of fever and—”

“Okay! I don’t need the details!” Catra huffs, hopping up to sit on the dining table before dramatically falling backwards until she’s staring up at the ceiling, the wood digs into her spine. The stem of the flower held over her heart, she announces, “Weaver’s making me go to the Brightmoon ball.”

“Oh? That one’s a pretty big deal, right?” Scorpia’s hands have returned to her flowers, rescuing the few that Catra very nearly squashed in lying down.

“I’m pretty sure the whole *country* is going to be there, everyone's vying for dibs on *wooing* our dear, future monarch.” Catra ends all exaggerated.

“Prince Adora?”

“The very one.”

“Huh. I didn’t know they were looking for a wife.” Catra’s head rolls, and she’ll admit, the sweetpea’s look *gorgeous* this year.

"Yeah, well, apparently they are now." Catra sits up then, swinging her legs underneath her. "And now that you realise what a waste of time this is going to be for me, any chance you might change your mind about the whole nightshade—"

Scorpia interrupts. "My mom pulled it out by the roots last year after I confessed what happened to you, so *no."*

"Damn, was it really a whole year ago?" Looking back, Weaver likely expected the ailment had been self-inflicted — she'd not pressed attendance on any social occasion since. Not that the older woman had suddenly grown a heart, but if Catra were to flat out *die*, some distant cousin or other would inherit the estate which would no doubt be an *inconvenience.*

"Fuck. Fine, but if I have to go to this thing, you're coming with me." It's actually Scorpia's *job* to do so, but it feels nice to display it as the same annoyance that had been handed to her.

"Of course, my lady."

Catra throws the flower at her friend's head. It does next to nothing considering it's practically weightless, but it gets the message across all the same.

The carriage lurching causes Catra's elbow to slip off the window ledge, destroying her showcase of boredom as she watched the countryside pass by. Her tiara slips from the motion, and she has to slide it back into place to stop it from falling. It's the only part of her attire she doesn't find antagonising; she's always liked the way it accentuates her ears. And it had belonged to her mother, once.

Scorpia sits on the padded seat across from her. Weaver must have decided she alone was an adequate babysitter because her

guardian hadn't felt the need to accompany Catra too.

The coach ride is four *delightful* long hours. She's lucky it's not *further*, her estate is not far from Brightmoon, some attendees would have been travelling for *days.* If it had been hosted in Eternia, the capital, it would have been a shorter ride still.

Catra'd never been particularly dedicated to her education — she'd always far preferred practical knowledge, and the stuffy, political nonsense that Weaver valued had floated straight out of her brain. But *everyone* knows the story of the Grayskulls. Luck seemed to have cast a shadow on the both of them, because Adora too, was an orphan; they'd been left in the care of the Brightmoon family after their parents were murdered over twenty years ago. The war that followed had been swift and *devastating*. And then the whole country had mourned.

The death of Catra's own had happened much more quietly. A couple of minor nobles being shot on the roadside doesn't tend to instigate a riot, though, apparently, Catra hadn't stopped crying for days.

Catra shakes the memories from her head, glancing toward her friend who's humming absentmindedly as they travel, eyes fixed to the novel in her hand. Scorpia's decked out in her armour now, red leather and chain-link that makes her already sturdy frame look even more mountainous. It's an *image*. And as heavy as it looks, Catra would choose it over her current confinements any day.

"I look fucking ridiculous." She'd declared, the second she'd stormed downstairs in the new, crimson-red garment to model it for her friend earlier that day.

Scorpia's eyes had turned to *gemstones*. "Aww, but you look so pretty!"

Catra had just groaned.

But like, she had mirrors, it wasn't that she thought she looked *bad*, to any meaning of the word. In a certain light, she could even see the appeal. Could even *agree* with Scorpia. But it just didn't feel *right.*

"I'm burning it the minute we get home," Catra announced.

Scorpia made a sound like a strangled lamb, even though she was aware Catra hardly ever followed through with that threat.

Catra's still debating how big of a bonfire she would need.

They must have been nearly there by now, and when she opens the carriage door, *leans,* to glance at the view ahead of them, she can make out the city in the dip of the next hill.

"Catra, you'll fall." Scorpia chides.

Catra sends her a flat look, she'd lept off faster-moving coaches than this before and landed perfectly balanced on her feet (Weaver, don't ask). But, she settled back in her chair anyway, clicking the door closed, task accomplished. Arms crossing, despite. "What are you reading anyway?"

Scorpia *flushes.* "Nothing."

"Oh my god," Catra flashes a toothy grin. "Please tell me you've spent the last few hours sat across from me reading smu—"

"No!" Scorpia's eyes go wide. "No, it's not. It's—" She turns the book, giving Catra a glimpse of the etchings and annotations on the inside. It's plants. Well, *flowers.* But this seems rather like a *new* fascination.

"Since when have you been so into horticulture?" Her friend's blush returns. One of Catra's eyebrows skyrockets, before her face turns sly. "It's rather convenient timing, isn't there a new family of florists moved into the village? I'm sure you could go to them asking all sorts of questions, maybe get on a first-name basis with that pretty daughter of theirs. Perfuma, right?" She asks, teasing,

because she's quite sure Scorpia is *certain* by the way she starts to shuffle in her seat.

Catra's not going to press. Her friend's bashful about these things at the best of times, and she needs her escort to not be a flustered mess for the remainder of the evening. So, it somewhat startles her when Scorpia elaborates of her own accord.

"Have you ever thought much... about marriage?"

Catra eyebrows raise a fraction. "What, like philosophically, or…?"

"I mean— Could you ever imagine yourself marrying someone, someday?" Scorpia's voice is quiet, thoughtful, *soft* even.

Catra shrugs. "Sure, I guess. Under the right circumstances."

It's silent for a beat, and then. "I hear Adora's supposed to be nice," Scorpia says it so cautiously, like she's placing a leg of lamb in front of a bear and then slowly backing away.

Catra's eyes roll to the top of her skull as she scoffs, "All I've heard is that they're a devout recluse." Scorpia sends her a flat look in reply as though that criticism is being hypocritical, which, fair, but uncalled for, frankly. "And I highly doubt they'll even spare me a glance all evening. Anyway, that would very much *not* be the right circumstances. Can you imagine me married to a Prince? Do I really seem the type to want to spend the rest of my life sitting in on court meetings dull enough to turn my brain to mashed potatoes, faking niceties with the local peasants and popping out the occasional heir?" She folds her arms. "No thank you."

It's quiet between them for a minute, Scorpia's running a finger thoughtfully over the binding of her book, and then she says, quietly. "But maybe it would be nice. Maybe anything would be nice..." Scorpia contemplated. "If you were beside someone you loved."

"Good lord, that flower girl has turned you into a sap."

As far as Catra's concerned, the evening is going *wonderfully.* They arrive late, she insists the coach laps the city a few times before they arrive at the manor — it means she can sneak in once they've ceased announcing each of the attendees by name. It's a quiet, unnoticed entrance. And then, she spends the next few hours tucked into a corner near the buffet table with Scorpia acting as her human shield.

See, *wonderfully*. And the tarts here are fucking *amazing.*

It wouldn't even be a lie to admit she's enjoying herself a little, preening under the eyes that scan her attire as though they're trying to be discreet about it. Magicat's are not common here. She's not the *only* one in the ballroom but she's one of *very few*. The term 'exotic' had been coined toward her once, she's pretty sure the gentleman still has the scars on his nose to show for it.

Scorpia interrupts her thoughts, it's probably for the best, someone has to keep her humble. "Oh! Is that Entrapta?"

"Where?" She turns, looking.

"There," Scorpia points across the room and the mass of people dancing or milling around, god forbid, *socialising*. "Next to lord Hordak."

"Aren't they engaged now?" She shoves another jam tart into her mouth from the plate Scorpia is carrying for her.

"Yeah."

"Huh," She mumbles. "Must just be here for the fanfare then."

"I'm gonna go talk to her, it's been so long."

“No.” Catra coughs, almost choking. “No, you’re *not.* Do *not* leave me here al— Scorp!” She hisses. But the taller woman is already striding across the room; Catra doesn’t have the gall to follow.

She’s left a little bit wide-eyed, retreating further into her corner. Her eyes flit over the nearest occupants, and she quickly brushes the crumbs off her cheeks with the back of her hands when she notices a familiar face approaching. She’s not certain yet if they’re going to be a salvation.

“Mermista,” She clears her throat. “It’s been a while.”

“Catra.” Her hips sway a little as she walks, it’s distracting in a way she knows Mermista must intend. She pauses in front of her, her dress a river of blue. “Always a pleasure, though a rare one. It seems even you couldn’t stay away from the social event of the season.”

“Well,” Catra tuts. “I tried my utmost. mother dearest *importuned*.” It’s said with every ounce of malice it deserves.

“Ah,” Mermista nods. “How is the witch?”

“Well, unfortunately.” She sighs, as though it’s the biggest inconvenience of her life. “Same iron grip as ever.”

“Perhaps tonight might offer you the opportunity to get out from under her thumb. How do you like your chances?”

“My chances?” Catra frowns minutely.

“With Adora.” Mermista clarifies, as though this whole event were nothing more than some gamble, some game of playing cards or the throw of the dice. “That is why we are all here, is it not? To take advantage of an opportunity?” She says it like it’s rehearsed, as though, underneath, she agrees this whole thing is ludicrous down to its bones.

“I have every intention of staying here until the first polite *opportunity* to *leave.*” Catra pokes a thumb over her shoulder to

the alcove she's spent most of the evening hiding in. Her arms fold. "Besides, I don't understand why everyone assumes my life is so miserable that I'd be willing to trade one headache for a hundred others. Weaver's not so bad, she grows on you."

Mermista hums, before adding, "Like a fungus." And it has Catra chortling. "Care for a drink?"

Catra nods, loosening a little. "Please."

"How have you been?" Catra asks, her nails tapping against the edge of the glass in her hand. It's ornate, decadent, completely *over the top*. The fuckers even have their house emblem worked into the base of it.

"The same as always I suppose, nothing ever really changes around here."

"Don't tell me you've got a sudden shortage of suitors at your door, pretty young thing like you?"

"You flatter me." Mermista places a hand dramatically over her heart. "But alas, none have yet to capture my heart as you have. Such a shame the stars are not aligned for us, my love."

Catra cackles, shoving her friend's arm lightly. "Shut up, you weirdo." She takes a swing from her drink then, grinning. There are some people, she thinks, that make tolerating these events worthwhile. "So, Merms, despite your *redirection*, and don't think that was subtle *at all*, word around town is there's a specific someone at your door quite often as of late."

Mermista sends Catra a glance as she's taking a sip from her own glass. Blinks, and declares, "You do remarkably well staying up to

date despite never leaving your house, do you know that? It's quite a skill."

Catra shrugs. "So. Is he here?"

"Disparagingly yes, I think the whole country has turned up for this circus. Blessedly, so long as you can get him caught up in a conversation with somebody else, he talks so rigorously that he tends not to notice when you slip away. It's been working a treat so far." It's all harsh words but it comes out *fond*, and there's no alibi for the slight blush over Mermista's cheeks.

"Ah, the wooing's going well then?"

"Indeed. Though he is an *incorrigible* flirt, and I do think sometimes he forgets who it is he's promised to." She glances over her shoulder like she's surveying the room for a specific face, the sound of a voice, before turning back to Catra. "It's nice to have a break every so often, I do wish he'd stop trying quite *so* hard and just shut up for five minutes. Conversing with you is far more pleasant, I'd much rather speak than be spoken *to*."

"Don't we all." Catra smiles, amused. "I fear your time may be up, however." Mermista cocks her head toward her, puzzled, until Catra indicates over Mermista's shoulder to the figure that's now walking towards them.

"Darling! There you are, I'd feared I'd lost you, my heart was in inconsolable *turmoil*." He moves to stand beside the two women. "Is this a friend? It's a pleasure to meet you," He *salutes* to Catra, of all things. She's polite enough to curtsey in reply, though when her mouth opens to introduce herself she finds him barreling on. "I had feared my betrothed would not be in good company, but it seems I was fretting for nought! Mermista you must introduce us! I don't believe we've met. I would, no doubt, have recognised a face like yours in a heartbeat, truly, one could not forget. Your family must be from Purrsia, correct? Or perhaps the further Felidae Isles? A *stunning* archipelago, if I do say so myself—"

Catra shoots Mermista a sharp look. Her friends just got this sappy grin on her face like she knows it's *a lot*, but can't help but find it endearing. "Sea Hawk dear, why don't you tell Catra about the most recent acquisition to your fleet?"

"Ah! Of course! A gallant ship, not the largest my family owns, by far, but the fastest in speed!"

Mermista, alarmingly, starts *backing* away once he's all together *lost* in his speech, an absolutely devilish smirk on her face. Catra sends another glance that she hopes translates as '*don't you dare*." But then the other woman's slipped away like a ghost and Sea Hawk left none the wiser. Catra, disastrously, is left laughing awkwardly at his jokes as he explains the long history of his family of merchant traders.

She tolerates it a few minutes more before she downs the last few inches of her drink, excusing herself. "Forgive me, I must find my guard, I seem to have misplaced her."

"Of course! I shall help you find her!" He sounds so delighted at the prospect too. She could almost see the appeal if his shade of charm wasn't quite so o*verbearing.*

"Really, there's no need." She takes a step sideways, and he starts, the good lord wept, to *follow.*

"The ashen haired, ox-like maiden, I believe?" He recalls as he falls in pace beside her, with a tone as though Catra herself wouldn't know what her best friend looks like.

"Thank you, but I think I can seek her out for myse—"

Catra's body collides with a thump into something else, she worries she's just stumbled, like a fool, straight into one of the pillars that supports the balcony above, until she realises the thing she's collided into is warm and soft, and has *arms* moving to steady her.

The first time Catra sees Adora, it's a glance of gold in the corner of her eye that brings her mind to the middle of summer and the fields of barley a few miles out the backdoor of her family's estate. It's the scent of lilacs that follows their skin like ribbons of silk; Catra feels her own heart thump within her ribcage at the memories of the bunches that hang from the kitchen's window cill. It's every way their voice is *soft* as they take a little breath, as though they're *stunned*. Perhaps understandably. Before Adora offers a bemused, "Hi."

Catra was certain that whatever tapestries they made of this moment in generations to come, it's the way her eyes drifted to meet Adora's that would be the very first touch of thread onto that blank canvas.

And it's *tragic*. Because, looking as handsome as *sin* in their white and gold naval accoutre, Adora's standing before her, and Catra' doesn't even *know.*

"Are you okay?" The blonde asks, snapping Catra out of her daze.

Sea Hawk makes an inane squeaking sound behind her. Catra rights herself, stepping back from her rescuer and brushing her hands to release the crinkles in her dress skirt. "Fine. Thank you." She breathes, embarrassed. The tiara on her head is *moving*, and she almost pulls back in shock before she realises her saviour is slipping it back into place.

"Sorry," they say, noticing her alarm. "I should have asked."

"It's— It's fine." Catra might be blushing a little, but the way the gaze of the person standing before her flickers over her figure as though they're attempting to *refrain* from doing so, has her insides performing *somersaults.* "Apologies, I should have been looking where I was going."

"No harm done," They reply, smiling faintly, *politely.*

Catra frowns, moving to leave, but something's preventing her from doing so. She has the unyielding feeling that she's met this

person before. A glimpse of a memory amongst a meadow of wildflowers and butterflies that have since turned to manicured lawns and topiaries.

They both start talking at the same time. "Do I kn—

"I suppose you'd like to dance?" They look *nervous*, wringing their hands, though at the same time *pressed*, like it's an uncomfortable chore they're trying to complete as politely and amiably as they are able.

Catra blinks, taken aback. "Uh, no. No, thank you, I won't put you through the trauma." She lets out an uncomfortable laugh before she glances back to Sea Hawk, who is now *gawking* at them.

Weird.

"Oh," They let out quietly, though when Catra turns to them again, the blonde's eyes are stuck on Catra's ears. Their forehead puzzles like perhaps they're having the same strange portent that Catra'd just been struggling over.

They've gathered a bit of an audience, it's making Catra fidgety. *Nosey blighters.*

Adora is conversing with Netossa when it happens. It's a nice respite to be talking to someone who holds no aspirations for her hand, it's comfortable, *companionly.*

And then, a body is colliding into hers. She catches them, steadies, only by the good grace that she has a habit of standing like a rock when she can't quite relax, and their smaller frame is nothing to compete.

Palms brace to balance against Adora's chest, before the armful of dark hair, wide eyes and a *stunning* crimson dress seems to rationalise her error, and pulls her hands away. Flinching, almost. Adora's still anchor, steady and firm just above her elbows.

The brunette at least certainly doesn't look dizzy. She does, however, look *gorgeous*. It almost seems an unhelpful thing to note, at the time, but Adora can't pull her eyes away from the irises that look like the very reflection of the coastland she'd grown up in. "Hi." She says, she hopes it doesn't sound too breathy. "Are you alright?"

"Fine. Thank you." The woman insists, her eyes flit over Adora's attire with a tone of indifference Adora's not familiar with, but finds herself wanting to *lean* into. It feels cold, but in that same way a lake of water is after a midsummer day that's been a little too *hot*.

The girl in her arms clears her throat. Adora takes that as an indication to remove her hands from where they've been securing. They fall to her sides, empty. She lasts a whole few seconds before they're fidgeting again, and the excuse presents itself when she notices the tiara now sits wonky atop the girl's head. Adora repositions it. Though guilt flushes her veins when the maiden before her visibly refrains from yanking her head away from the light brush of contact. *That was probably a bit forward, Adora.* "Sorry, I should have asked."

"It's— It's fine." She placates, her face flushed, no doubt from embarrassment. Though now they are a step apart, Adora's struggling to keep her gaze from wandering. It is *such* a pretty dress. Adora swallows*.* "Apologies, I should have been looking where I was going."

"No harm done," Adora replies. It's probably the most candid introduction she's had all evening, and she doesn't even know this woman's *name* yet. And those *ears.* The fur is soft there — bizarrely, it's a fact she *knows*, and not merely from looking. Adora *knows* that to run her hands through would remind her of

the silken fur of a baby rabbit, knows the warm, chesty rumble that would emit from her ribcage in response. She wants to *try.* But doing so would also be *wildly* inappropriate, so she *doesn't.*

Adora glances to check, there is no ring on the girl's hand, so she takes a breath, and asks. "I suppose you'd like to dance?" She doesn't actually pick up on what it is she's just interrupted, only that the brunette's face has turned *bewildered.*

"Uh, no. No, thank you, I won't put you through the trauma." The laugh she lets out is soft and *bashful* and it makes Adora, inexplicably, *melt*. Before she computes the answer she's just been given.

"Oh," Adora lets out quietly. It's her first rejection of the evening, first rejection *ever*, actually, and she's not sure if that's the sole reason she feels a little deflated, or if, perhaps, she'd for once truthfully been *hoping.* It is *such* a pretty dress — Adora might actually be a bit star-struck, noticeably too, if Netossa's growing smirk is anything to go by.

"Catra, my dear!" A moustached man materializes from her periphery — Adora admits she'd lost all recollection of their surroundings. *Catra, her name's Catra.* Adora notes it down like it's the most important addition her diary has ever witnessed. "Are you quite alright, you're not feeling woozy at all? I do believe Dr Lance is around somewhere, maybe it is of precedence that we find Scorpia and let you rest somewhere quiet for a moment?"

Catra actually snarls at him. Adora's eyes go wide at the sheer gumption and *crassness* of it, and how many times today has she wished she'd been able to do the same?

Netossa, astoundingly, *joins in.* "Darling, it would be sensible not to push yourself, perhaps refraining for this dance *is* a wise choice." But the way Catra's eyes flash at the remark, the way her fur stands on end just the slightest bit, suggests it's a taunt, not a nicety. Though a carefully and calculatedly placed one, chess pieces moving over a board in a game Adora fears she's never

been taught to play. Netossa appears to be moving her pieces for her. She'll decide later if she's grateful.

Adora knows she doesn't get out much, but she's already gathered that many of their guests know each other far better than *she* knows her *subjects*. She swallows thickly, again.

She watches dumbly as moustache continues, though *he* at least seems sincere, "perhaps we should find you a bench, or a chair. Drink can affect us in such strange ways, it is nothing to be asham __"

"Good lord, I'm *fine*," Catra asserts, her eyes rolling to the heavens. Adora notices a flash of the girl's claws and panics for a second, but it's not *him* she's reaching out for.

And then—

Uh.

She's *taking Adora's hand,* her hold nothing but gentle, before she pulls them both toward the dance floor like she has something to prove.

Agreeing to a dance out of *spite* might not be making the best first impression, Catra acknowledges, and she's not even certain why she cares about that all of a sudden — but once the flame of it has died down, her feet dragging them both towards the centre of the dance floor, she finds herself wavering. Just *a little.*

She turns to the blonde, dropping their hand when she realises it's still in hers. Her fingers flex. "You going to lead or what?" It might be a jab at how *dazed* they look right now, but she also *needs* the guidance if she's not going to make a fool of herself.

Adora thinks her breath might actually catch to a degree that it would be evident to anyone looking, as she takes a step forward, slips a hand around Catra's waistline, and pulls her *close.* It's all her senses can focus on for a beat. Before their palms join too, Catra's hand moves to her shoulder, and then the music *starts.*

Catra's heart stutters at the proximity, she'd forgotten about this particular part of dancing, the utter lack of *personal space*. Truthfully, she's spent more hours waltzing with Scorpia around her own bedroom than she has at balls. But see, Scorpia is a *friend*, being close with her is familiar, and most certainly had not sent tingles across her skin from every point of contact like *this.*

Her partner's hand feels large against the small of her back, but it's not confining, as they glide over the floor. The pace is slow, thank the heavens. But that also means instead of concentrating on where her feet need to be, her mind zero's in on the feel of the hand that's warm against hers. There's no calluses, but the skin isn't exactly soft either, and she imagines they must spend more time practising with a sword than they have any duty given need to.

And, contrastingly, Scorpia's eyes had always looked *fond*, when they'd practised. She thinks their learning to dance together was a large instigator in the taller girls crush, but her shade of smitten had never looked like *this.*

Catra swallows.

It’s strange, she thinks, when she glances over her shoulder, (those blue eyes are becoming a bit *much*) how the whole room seems to be rotating around the two of them, like how the moons and planets revolve around the sun. It’s apt, she considers, based on the colour of her dress. The gravity of it sits right over her lungs though, and she’s a little worried about hyperventilating.

And then, *god, fuck*—

She *stumbles.*

Catra lets out a sound as she trips over Adora’s foot. It’s a very muffled squeak; Adora thinks it’s *adorable*, but she doesn’t dwell too long before her arm tightens around Catra’s lower back. Pulling their bodies flush together and *lifting*. Spinning them in a direction that will assist the magicat to regain her balance without it looking obvious to observers what’s just happened. It’s the most indiscernible faux pas Adora’s managed this evening.

The blonde lets out a soft laugh. It sounds like the flicker of stars in the night sky after a day that’s been incontestably clouded over. “Did no one ever teach you how to dance? Or how to walk, for that matter?”

It’s such an affectionate question. There’s no malice behind it at all, and Catra can feel her partner start to lead them through a slower pattern over the marbled floor, and everyone surrounding them just kind of… *adapts* to give them room.

Catra feels her whole body loosen instantly.

The girl in her arms blinks at her, a little bit flushed, Adora realises she has not yet released the grip of her arm around her waist. So she does. Catra glances to the ground then, her face appears to scrunch up like an irate rabbit, before she's looking back up, her expression chagrined. Catra shrugs. "Eh, being an orphan has its perks."

"Oh," Adora can feel her own face fall, and it's proved further still by the way Catra's gaze flickers to more neutral territory over her shoulder, or possibly *through* it, it's hard to tell. "I guess we have that in common then."

Catra pauses, glances up, then tilts her head at her.

That makes Adora frown. She clears her throat but manages to stammer despite it. "About, uh, the orphan thing." Surely she would know that already? There wasn't a single person in the kingdom who didn't.

"I'm— I'm sorry," Catra says.

Adora's grateful she doesn't say more, condolences are misplaced at the best of times, but she knows by the way Catra's eyes turn gentle that she means it *wholeheartedly* — and that's a rare thing, she's learned. So, Adora replies. "Me too."

"Anyway, since we're sharing our deepest, darkest secrets," Catra clears her throat free of emotion. "Who *did* teach you?"

"Teach me what?" A divot appears over their forehead.

“To dance.” Catra’s certain that anybody capable of rescuing their dance partner from self-sabotage that *smoothly* could only have built that level of finesse over *hours and hours.*

“Oh, my aunt insisted on lessons.” They tell her. “She would’ve been mortified if I’d show up to my first ball looking like a complete buffoon.”

“That’s how you’d describe my dancing?” Catra asks innocently, her smirk anything but. “Mortifying, buffoon like?”

“What? No!” The blonde looks *alarmed*. “No, I didn’t mean it like that at all, I just meant—”

Catra interrupts. “You’re quite skittish, has anyone ever told you that?”

They clear their throat, flustered. Their voice comes out quiet and squeaky. “A few times.”

“So, an Aunt, huh? Distant family must be nice to have as a backup.”

Adora frowns. “You don’t have any?”

“Nope, none.” Catra shakes her head. “I mean, apparently there are cousins back on the islands, but nobody close by.”

“Oh, That…”

“Sucks? Catra shrugs, it’s with a little less of that playful energy she had before. “Sure, you get used to it.”

Adora softens at that. “Alright, so who taught *you* then?”

"Weren't you just insinuating I hadn't been taught at *all*?" Catra points out, her indignance all for show. Adora waits. "A knight, while they were still a squire, actually," Catra admits then. "So that probably explains some things."

Adora lets out a gentle laugh, it's her first one for days, maybe even *weeks.* She can feel it working to untangle the knots in her muscles like a remedy. She feels lighter as they move together, she wonders, fleetingly, if this is what dancing is *supposed* to feel like.

It's a shame; Adora knows the song, knows the melody and the pace of it, she knows it's nearly *over*. She doesn't want it to be. With a wave of her hand, she could probably have them repeat the conclusion until the whole ballroom is sick of hearing it, but she also doesn't want to draw *more* attention to them. And it would, no doubt, be *noticed.*

Catra grows shifty now the conversation has slowed, she keeps glancing over Adora's shoulder as they spin in a slow pattern, as though she's scanning their surroundings.

"Why is everybody staring at us?" She says, *whispers*, as the last bars of the song play out like passerines at twilight.

Adora just watches her. A little bit awestruck at the taught line of her jaw, the freckles like constellations over the bridge of her nose and the flecks of honey in the eye that's closest to her. *Surely she knows.* "I couldn't *possibly* imagine."

Surely she *knows.*

Catra's eyes dart to hers then. A beat, before they're plummeting down Adora's attire and acknowledging, finally, the uniform for what it is. A flash of recognition follows, though it's quickly dawned by… dread? *No, that doesn't make sense.*

The dance hasn't even finished yet and Catra's already pulling away, her eyes as wide as harvest moons. The loss of warmth against Adora's torso is immediately obvious, cold air replaces the

space she'd taken up, and Adora hadn't even been conscious of how *close* they'd been.

They both stare, for a second.

"Hi," Adora breaths, Catra lets out this distressed little laugh in return and it has Adora's heart dropping in her sternum.

A few beats later and the rest of the dance floor follows, separating from their partners, dispersing as the last note plays. Catra doesn't reply, doesn't even say goodbye. She just slips away, *flees,* into the mass of people like a raindrop falling into a stream.

Adora's left too disoriented to follow.

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